

vagus

Nerve Activities

Vagus Nerve Activities



Buzz
Like a
Bee

**Materials Needed:**

- The Kindy Coach bee visual card, or
- A picture of a bee, or
- A small bee object (toy, figurine, etc.)



Buzz Like a Bee

Benefits:

- Stimulates the Vagus Nerve: Promotes relaxation and calm.
- Helps manage stress and anxiety.
- Promotes Self-Regulation

Instructions:

- Gather children and show them the bee visual card, picture, or object. Explain they will be buzzing like bees. Demonstrate buzzing by humming "zzzz" with your mouth closed. Show how to take a deep breath in and hum on the exhale.
- Integrate this activity into the daily routine. For example:
 - Morning circle time
 - Transition times
 - After high-energy activities
 - Before naptime or quiet time
 - Whenever a child feels overwhelmed

Vagus Nerve Activities



Spin Breathing

Play Move Improve

Parasympathetic Play Program

Vagus Nerve Activities



Blow Bubbles

Play Move Improve

Parasympathetic Play Program



Spin Breathing



Materials:

- Bilibo chair or desk chair

Instructions:

Have children sit on a swing, desk chair, or Bilibo chair. Guide them to take a slow, deep breath in as they swing or rotate in one direction, then exhale slowly as they move in the opposite direction. Encourage them to observe their environment, noting colors and sounds. Ask them to describe how their body feels (e.g., "hands are tight," "feet are light"). Prompt them to notice if breathing is easier in a particular direction and if they have a preferred direction of movement.

What to look for:

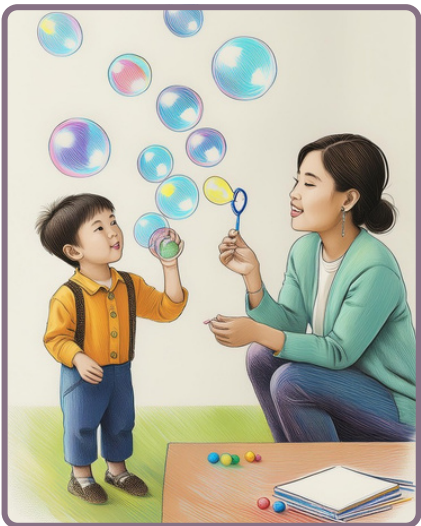
Observe the children's ability to coordinate their breath with the swinging or rotating motion. Watch their focus as they describe their surroundings and bodily sensations. Note any preferences for direction or breathing pattern. Pay attention to signs of relaxation or increased body awareness. Look for improvements in their descriptive language as the activity progresses.

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Blow Bubbles



Materials Needed:

- Bubble solution and wand

Benefits:

- Blowing bubbles stimulates the vagus nerve, promoting a sense of relaxation and calmness. It helps to reduce anxiety, boost concentration, and teach children to manage their emotions and behaviour through playful deep breathing.

Instructions:

- Gather the children and show them the bubble solution and wand. Explain that blowing bubbles will help them feel calm and focused.
- Demonstrate how to dip the wand into the solution, take a deep breath, and gently blow to create bubbles.
- Invite the children to take turns blowing bubbles, encouraging them to focus on taking slow, deep breaths and gently exhaling. Suggest that they watch the bubbles float away and notice how it makes them feel.
- After everyone has had a chance to blow bubbles, gather the children together and discuss how they feel.

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Belly Breathing

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Roar Like a Dinosaur

Play Move Improve

Parasympathetic Play Program



Belly Breathing



Materials:

- No equipment needed

Instructions:

Have children sit or lie in a comfortable position. Ask them to place both hands gently on their belly. Guide them to take slow, deep breaths, focusing on the movement of their belly. Encourage them to feel their belly rise as they inhale and fall as they exhale. Use simple language to explain the process, such as "Let's make our tummy big like a balloon when we breathe in, and then let it get small when we breathe out." Continue this for 5-10 breaths or as long as the children remain engaged.

What to look for:

Observe the children's ability to focus on their breathing and belly movement. Watch for the visible rise and fall of their abdomen with each breath. Note any initial difficulty in coordinating breath with belly movement. Pay attention to signs of relaxation or calming as they continue the exercise. Look for improvements in their breath control and focus as they practice.

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Roar Like a Dinosaur



Materials Needed:

- The Kindy Coach dinosaur visual card
- A picture of a dinosaur, or
- A small dinosaur toy or figurine

Benefits:

- Stimulates the Vagus Nerve: Promotes relaxation and calm.
- Helps manage stress and anxiety.
- Supports children to regulate emotions and behaviour.

Instructions:

- Gather children and show them the dinosaur visual card, picture, or object. Explain they will be roaring like dinosaurs. Demonstrate roaring by taking a deep breath in and making a gentle roaring sound as you exhale.
- Encourage children to place their hands on their chest or throat to feel the vibration. Guide them to take deep breaths and roar for a few minutes, varying the volume and intensity.
- Ask children to sit quietly and notice how they feel. Encourage sharing of experiences (eg. how does their body feel now, where did they feel the dinosaur roar in their body)

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Teddy Squeeze

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Blow a Feather

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Teddy Squeeze



Materials:

- Soft toy or cushion

Instructions:

Provide each child with a stuffed teddy bear or another soft, huggable object. Demonstrate the activity: give the teddy a tight hug or squeeze for 3 to 5 seconds, then completely relax your arms and body. Guide the children to repeat this sequence several times. Encourage them to notice how their muscles feel during the squeeze and the relaxation phases.

What to look for:

Observe the children's ability to alternate between squeezing tightly and relaxing completely. Watch their facial expressions during each phase for signs of focus or relaxation. Note any difficulties in maintaining the squeeze for the full 3-5 seconds. Pay attention to how quickly they can transition from tension to relaxation. Look for signs of increased body awareness as the activity progresses.



Blow a Feather



Materials Needed:

- A craft store feather for each child

Benefits:

- Blowing a feather helps to stimulate the vagus nerve, encouraging relaxation and calmness. This activity can also reduce anxiety, improve focus, and teach children how to regulate their emotions and behaviour.

Instructions:

- Begin by gathering the children in a comfortable area and distributing a feather to each child. Explain that they will be using the feathers to help them feel calm and relaxed by blowing on them gently.
- Demonstrate how to hold the feather in front of you, take a deep breath in through your nose, and blow out gently through your mouth to make the feather move.
- Invite the children to take deep breaths together and blow on their feathers, focusing on slow, controlled exhalations. Encourage them to watch the feather float and move as they blow, noticing the gentle sensation and the calming effect it has.

Vagus Nerve Activities



Fast and Slow Wall Push Ups

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Spray Mist

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Fast Slow Wall Push Ups



Materials:

- No equipment needed

Instructions:

Position children in front of a wall, standing arm's length away. Demonstrate a wall push-up: place hands on the wall, shoulder-width apart, then bend elbows to lean in and push back. Explain the two speeds:

- "Fast": Do quick push-ups for 10 seconds, counting aloud.
- "Slow": Do one push-up as slowly as possible, counting the seconds it takes. Alternate between "Fast" and "Slow" rounds, allowing rest between each.

What to look for:

Observe the children's ability to adjust their speed between fast and slow rounds. Watch their form during push-ups, noting any improvements in technique. Pay attention to their counting - both in terms of accuracy and their ability to multitask while exercising. Note any signs of increased body awareness or self-regulation as they control their movements.



Spray Mist



Materials Needed:

- Scented sprays safe for children or
- Small spray bottles filled with plain water

Benefits:

- Using a water mist spray bottle can promote sensory integration, particularly tactile and proprioceptive sensations. This activity helps reduce children's anxiety and stress by providing calming sensory input through the gentle mist of water, stimulating the vagus nerve and promoting relaxation.

Instructions:

- Provide each child with a small spray bottle filled with water.
- Explain that they will be using the spray bottles to feel the calming mist on their face. This will help them relax and feel refreshed by taking deep breaths and enjoying the gentle sensation of the water mist.
- Show the children how to spray a small amount of the water into the air or onto their hands, and then gently mist their face.
- Encourage them to focus on the refreshing, calming effect of the mist. Ask the children to notice how the mist feels on their skin.

Vagus Nerve Activities



Frog Leaps

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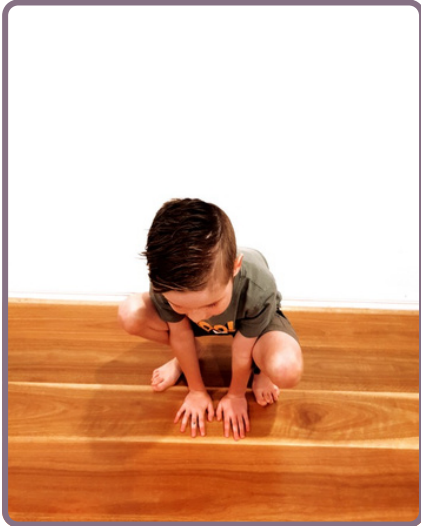
Dance Like a Monkey

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Frog Leaps



Materials:

- No equipment needed

Instructions:

Ask children to stand on the spot with their feet shoulder-width apart and then jump up and down, imitating the movements of a frog.

Children should try to keep their eyes focused on a fixed point on the ground as they bob down, then look up high as they leap up, to challenge their vestibular system.

What to look for:

Observe how well children mimic the frog's movements as they jump up and down, focusing on their ability to coordinate the bobbing motion and leap up in a way that imitates the frog.

Pay attention to their ability to maintain balance and control during these movements while managing their visual focus, which can challenge their vestibular system.

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Dance Like a Monkey



Materials Needed:

- The Kindy Coach monkey visual card,
- A picture of a monkey, or
- A small monkey toy or figurine

Benefits:

- Dancing and making sounds like a monkey can stimulate the vagus nerve, encouraging relaxation and calmness. This activity helps reduce anxiety, enhance focus, and teach children to regulate their emotions and behaviour through playful movement and vocalisation.

Instructions:

- Gather the children in a spacious area where they can move freely. Show them the monkey visual card, picture, or toy, and explain that they will be dancing and making sounds like monkeys to help them feel happy and calm.
- Demonstrate how to move like a monkey by jumping, swinging arms, and making "ooh-ooh, ah-ah" sounds. Encourage the children to join in, moving and making sounds together.
- Invite the children to imitate your movements and sounds, encouraging them to be as playful and expressive as possible.
- After a few minutes, have the children sit quietly and notice how their bodies feel.

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Cross- Body Ear Tracing

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Chew on Ice Chips

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Cross Body Ear-Tracing



Materials:

- No equipment needed

Instructions:

Begin by asking the child to lie on their tummy on a comfortable surface. Guide the child to use their left pointer finger to slowly trace the outline of their right ear. Once they've completed tracing their right ear, have them use their right pointer finger to slowly trace the outline of their left ear. Encourage the child to repeat this process five times with each hand, maintaining a slow and deliberate pace throughout the exercise.

What to look for:

As the child performs this activity, observe their body awareness by noticing if they can easily locate their ears without looking. Pay attention to their bilateral coordination, watching how well they can control movements on both sides of their body. Look for any hesitation or difficulty when the child reaches across their body, which indicates their ability to cross the midline. Observe their fine motor control, looking for smooth, controlled movements as they trace their ear.

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Chew on Ice Chips



Materials Needed:

- Small ice chips (ensure they are appropriately sized to prevent choking)

Benefits:

- Chewing on ice chips can help reduce heart rate and body temperature, which can have a calming effect on the body. This activity also stimulates the vagus nerve, promoting relaxation and reducing anxiety. It's particularly useful during stressful transitions, such as drop-off time, to help children manage their emotions and feel more settled.

Instructions:

- Gather the children in a comfortable area and provide each child with a few small ice chips. Explain that chewing on ice chips can help them feel cooler and calmer by reducing their heart rate and body temperature.
- Show them how to take an ice chip and chew on it slowly, paying attention to the cold sensation and how it makes their body feel.
- Encourage the children to focus on the sensation of the cold ice in their mouth and the calming effect it has on their body. Remind them to chew slowly and mindfully.

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Torch Tap

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Hiss Like a Snake

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Torch Tap



Materials:

- Torch

Instructions:

In a darkened area of the room, give one child a torch. This child is designated as the “pointer” and uses their torch to point to locations around the room (on the ground, with safety being top priority). Children must move and balance while trying to tap the location of the torch gently with their hands or feet, challenging their visual tracking and balance skills.

Another version of this activity is for the child with the torch to be ‘it’, and children try to avoid where the torch light is, so they don’t go ‘out’.

What to look for:

Assess how well they regulate their actions, maintaining balance and moving gently while interacting with the designated areas of light.

Pay attention to their adaptability, observing how quickly and purposefully they adjust their movements in response to the changing locations of the torchlight.



Hiss Like a Snake



Materials Needed:

- The Kindy Coach snake visual card, or
- A picture of a snake, or
- A small snake toy or figurine

Benefits:

- Hissing like a snake helps to stimulate the vagus nerve, promoting a sense of relaxation and calm. This activity can also reduce anxiety, improve focus, and teach children how to regulate their emotions and behaviour.

Instructions:

- Gather the children and show them the snake visual card, picture, or toy. Explain that they will be pretending to be snakes and making hissing sounds to help them relax. Demonstrate how to take a deep breath in and then slowly exhale while making a “ssssss” sound, like a snake hissing.
- Invite the children to stand up, take a deep breath together, and hiss gently on the exhale. Encourage them to feel the vibrations in their chest and throat and to make the hissing sound as long and smooth as possible.
- After a few minutes of hissing, ask the children to sit quietly and notice how their bodies feel.

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Trace Ball on Line

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Breathing with a Pinwheel

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Trace Ball on Line



Materials:

- Masking tape
- Tennis ball

Instructions:

Create an engaging movement path by placing a 1.5 meter strip of masking tape in your classroom entry area or between activity spaces, then place a basket of tennis balls nearby. As children arrive or transition between activities, each child takes a ball and traces it along the tape line with one hand, naturally slowing their movement while building hand-eye coordination.

What to look for:

Look for any signs of dizziness or reluctance to move their head. See if children are able to maintain their focus on tracing the ball along the line without losing focus or being distracted by the children around them.

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Breathing with a Pinwheel



Materials Needed:

- Pinwheels

Benefits:

- Blowing a pinwheel stimulates the vagus nerve, promoting a sense of relaxation and calm. This activity can help reduce anxiety, improve focus, and teach children how to regulate their emotions and behaviour through mindful breathing and visual feedback.

Instructions:

- Provide each child with a pinwheel.
- Explain that they will be using the pinwheel to help them feel calm and relaxed by taking deep breaths and blowing on the pinwheel to make it spin.
- Show the children how to hold the pinwheel in front of them, take a deep breath in through their nose, and blow out slowly through their mouth to make the pinwheel spin. Emphasize the importance of slow, controlled exhalation.
- Invite the children to take turns blowing on their pinwheels. Encourage them to focus on their breath and the movement of the pinwheel, feeling the calming effects of the activity.

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Funny Faces

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Tunnel Ball

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Funny Faces



Materials Needed:

- Handheld mirrors or a large wall mirror

Benefits:

- Making funny faces in the mirror can promote sensory integration, particularly visual and proprioceptive sensations. This playful activity helps reduce children's anxiety and stress by engaging their facial muscles and providing a fun way to explore self-expression.

Instructions:

- Provide each child with a handheld mirror or use a large wall mirror where children can stand and see themselves.
- Explain that they will be making funny faces in the mirror to explore different facial expressions and how they feel. This will help them relax and have fun.
- Show some funny faces in the mirror yourself, exaggerating expressions like big smiles, wide eyes, puffed cheeks, and silly tongues. Encourage laughter and playfulness.
- Invite the children to make their own funny faces in the mirror, exploring different expressions and noticing how their faces move.



Tunnel Ball



Materials:

- Medium sized ball
- Floor marker to keep children in similar positions

Instructions:

Encourage children to play a fun game of "tunnel ball" where children line up in a row of two or more, with their legs apart, and pass the ball through their legs to the child behind them.

The last child in line runs to the front with the row and continues the pattern, now passing it through and under their legs.

What to look for:

Monitor their coordination and teamwork as they pass the ball through and under their legs in a sequential pattern. Assess how well they coordinate the ball passing, ensuring it smoothly travels through the row without interruptions. Additionally, monitor the transitions as the last child runs to the front, assessing their ability to seamlessly continue the passing sequence.

